

# ADR 0131 — A bisect session has one owner, and it is git

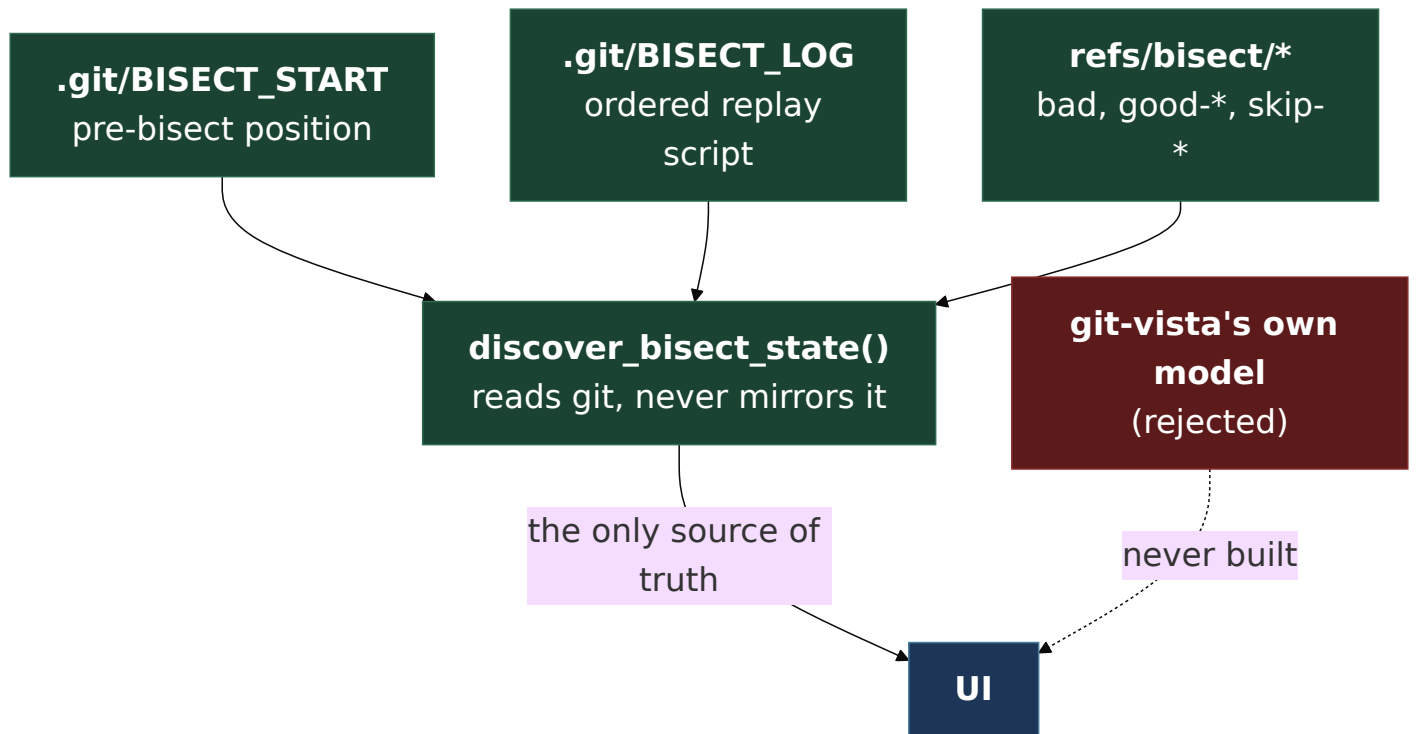
- **Status:** Proposed — design settled, implementation in progress
- **Date:** 2026-09-05
- **Milestone / issue:** M5.34 — A durable, resumable visual bisect session (#87)
- **Supersedes / superseded by:** —

## Context

---

`git bisect` already keeps its own durable, on-disk state for a bisect session: `.git/BISECT_START` (the pre-bisect position to return to), `.git/BISECT_LOG` (an ordered, replayable script of every `start` / `good` / `bad` / `skip` command run), and `refs/bisect/bad` / `refs/bisect/good-<oid>` / `refs/bisect/skip-<oid>` (the current known-good, known-bad and skipped commits). None of that disappears when this application restarts, and none of it can be told apart from what git itself would show a user running `git bisect` from a terminal.

#87's acceptance criteria are: existing bisect state is discovered, sessions survive restart, every decision is journaled, reset is reliable, and automated test execution goes through a reviewed adapter rather than browser-supplied shell. The central risk this ADR heads off is building a **second** model of "what step are we on" that can disagree with git's own — the way a UI ends up confidently showing a bisect that git has already finished, or offering "mark good" when there is no bisect running at all.



Verified empirically (not assumed) in a scratch repo before any of this was designed, because guessing at git's own plumbing has been wrong here before:

- `git bisect start <bad> <good...>` writes `BISECT_START` with the pre-bisect ref/branch name, and moves HEAD to a candidate — recorded in the reflog as a **plain** `checkout: moving from X to Y`, with no `bisect:` prefix at all. Unlike `merge/rebase/cherry-pick`, a bisect step is **indistinguishable from an ordinary checkout by reflog text alone**.
- `git bisect skip` creates `refs/bisect/skip-<oid>` (confirmed by direct inspection) — so the current good/bad/skip set is fully recoverable from `refs/bisect/*` alone, but **order** is not: only `BISECT_LOG`'s command lines preserve the sequence a person made their decisions in.
- The step that finds the culprit prints `<oid> is the first bad commit` and **exits 1** — a verified quirk: exit code alone cannot distinguish "found it" from "the command failed," and `BISECT_START` / `BISECT_LOG` / `refs/bisect/*` are **not** cleared automatically. `git bisect reset` is a separate, explicit step that the user (or this app) must still run.

# Decision

---

## 1. Git's on-disk state is authoritative; the app reads it, never mirrors it

"Discover existing bisect state" means: does `.git/BISECT_START` exist (bisect in progress); what does `refs/bisect/bad` / `refs/bisect/good-*` / `refs/bisect/skip-*` currently list (enumerated via `git for-each-ref refs/bisect`, one read, no parsing of git's prose); and what is the ordered history (`BISECT_LOG`'s `git bisect <verb> <args>` command lines, parsed as the structured replay script git itself defines that format to be — not its `#`-prefixed comment lines, which are only git's own human-readable annotation and can drift from the ref state on a detached/rebased history).

No separate journal is the source of truth for "what step are we on." The app's own activity journal (below) is an audit trail of decisions, not a second state machine that could disagree with git about the session itself.

## 2. "Finished" is derived from the candidate range, never from git's printed sentence or its exit code

A bisect is finished when the commit range `<bad> ^<good_1> ^<good_2> ...` (via `git rev-list`, skip commits deliberately left inside the range since they were never resolved as good) collapses to exactly one commit — that commit is the culprit. This is computed the same way ADR 0037 requires elsewhere in this codebase: read state, don't parse prose. It also sidesteps the verified exit-code quirk above — the executor never branches on `git bisect bad/good`'s exit status to decide success; it inspects `stderr` only for a genuine refusal (e.g. "You need to give me at least one good and one bad revision") and otherwise re-reads ref state unconditionally afterward.

### 3. Three new `GitOperation` variants, following `SequenceContinue` / `SequenceSkip` / `SequenceAbort` 's shape exactly

```
BisectStart { bad: Commit0id, good: Vec<Commit0id> },
BisectMark { verdict: BisectVerdict },    // Good | Bad | Skip
BisectReset,
```

`BisectMark` carries no commit field. Precedent:

`SequenceContinue` 's own doc comment — "which sequence is not a field... asking the caller would invite them to be wrong about it... the executor reads which one is in progress." The current bisect candidate is whatever `HEAD` already is; accepting a commit from the client would let a stale client mark the *wrong* commit good or bad, silently corrupting the search. The executor refuses with `409` when `BISECT_START` does not exist, exactly as `sequence_exec::exec_sequence` refuses when neither `CHERRY_PICK_HEAD` nor `REVERT_HEAD` exists.

These three go through the ordinary planner pipeline — `effects.rs` (`WorktreeEffect::FilesRewritten`, `IndexEffect::Rebuilt`, `NetworkNeed::Local` for all three, matching `CheckoutBranch`: a bisect step *is* a checkout, just one git drives internally), `census_for`, risk classification, dispatch, the sandbox `argv` table, and the golden fixture — the same closed vocabulary as every other mutation (ADR 0015, ADR 0017). `refs/bisect/*` are internal plumbing the reviewer never needs to see move, the same D5 posture `PushStash` and `fetch_remote` already take, so the plan's `RefChange` list stays empty for all three variants.

### 4. `RiskLevel` and a new `RecoveryStrategy::BisectReset`

`BisectStart` / `BisectMark`: `RiskLevel::Reversible` — `HEAD` moves, but nothing is destroyed. `BisectReset`: also `Reversible` — it returns to the recorded pre-bisect position and touches nothing else.

Recovery needed a real decision. `head_moves` 's `ResetRef` shape (used by `SequenceContinue` / `Skip`) is keyed to a **checked-out branch** — bisect runs on a **detached** `HEAD` by design, so there is

no branch tip to pin at shape time, and `NotNeeded` would be dishonest (something *did* move). Neither existing variant fits, so this ADR adds one:

```
/// The undo for a bisect step is a full `git bisect reset`, not a ba
/// move – it may reattach a branch (`BISECT_START` can name one), and
/// also clears `refs/bisect/*` and the log a raw `ResetRef` would le
/// dangling. Stating `ResetRef` here would claim a mechanical undo t
/// app does not perform.
BisectReset,
```

`BisectStart / BisectMark` declare `RecoveryStrategy::BisectReset`; `BisectReset` itself declares `NotNeeded`. This is the same shape as `SequenceAbort` being a sibling operation rather than a recovery hint on `Continue / Skip` — the vocabulary already has precedent for "the undo is a different, explicit, named operation," this ADR just gives that precedent its own tag instead of overloading `NotNeeded`.

## 5. Notes are app-only metadata, not a `GitOperation`

A free-text note on a candidate commit changes nothing git will ever look at — it never moves a ref, never touches the index. Routing it through the planner/plan-review/journal machinery built for repository mutations would be ceremony around a fact that isn't one. Notes persist in a small durable file keyed by commit oid (`.git/git-vista/bisect-notes.json`, alongside the existing `.git/git-vista/journal.jsonl` — same directory, same "lives with the repo, survives restart" property), read/written directly by their own narrow endpoint. They are cleared when `BisectReset` runs, since they're scoped to the session they were written during.

## 6. Every decision is journaled through the existing activity journal, under one new `ActivityKind::Bisect`

`ActivityKind` is a closed enum with "no catch-all" as a stated design principle (`Other` exists only for git writes this app doesn't yet recognise). A bisect step is fully understood by the app that just ran it, so folding it into `Other` — or worse, into `Checkout`, which would make it indistinguishable from an ordinary branch

switch in the feed — is exactly the miscategorisation the enum's own doc comment warns against. One variant, `Bisect`, covers start/mark/reset; the *summary* string (already a free-text field on every `ActivityEvent`) carries which verb and which commit, the same way one `BranchDeleted` kind covers both a safe and a force delete and lets the summary say which. `journal_app_event` is called from each executor exactly as every other operation already does — no new journal, no new file format.

An externally-run bisect (a human typing `git bisect` in a terminal) is **not** reclassified by this ADR. Point 1 above already found that its reflog trace is a bare `checkout: moving from X to Y` — indistinguishable from an ordinary checkout by text, and distinguishing it would need cross-referencing reflog timestamps against `BISECT_LOG` modification times, a parse-git's-timing exercise this ADR declines for the same reason ADR 0037 declines parsing its prose. Out of scope for #87, which journals the app's *own* actions (always routed through `journal_app_event` with an explicit kind already) — not reflog forensics on actions it didn't take.

## 7. The reviewed adapter: a closed, compiled-in table — not a runtime config file

"Automated tests use a reviewed adapter, never browser-supplied shell" is a security boundary (ADR 0017, ADR 0030's exact shape: the server owns argv construction, the client only ever selects from a server-declared set). The question this ADR has to answer is *where the reviewed set lives*.

This app has no existing per-repo, human-edited config file — the catalog (ADR 0003) is populated by directory scanning at startup, not by a file an operator hand-maintains. Adding one just for bisect adapters would introduce a new trust boundary (a file format, a parser, a reload story) nothing else in this issue asks for, for a feature that — per the issue's own wording, "optional constrained test execution" — is explicitly not required to ship with any adapter wired up.



So: a closed Rust enum, `BisectAdapterId`, compiled into the server, is the intended shape of the entire reviewed set, once it exists. "Reviewed" would mean what it literally says — a human reviewing the exact argv in a PR before it could ever run, the same review every other line of this server already gets, rather than an operator-editable file this ADR would have to design a trust model for. A future slice's client would `GET` the (possibly empty) list of configured adapters and `POST {id}` to run one, with no field anywhere in that request shape a string could occupy.

**What #87 actually ships is narrower than that design: no adapter, and no endpoint of any kind.** `BisectAdapterId` exists in `bisect_exec.rs` today as an unwired, zero-variant placeholder — `#[allow(dead_code)]`, nothing constructs it, nothing matches on it, no route reads it. The real safety property right now is **scope, not type**: there is no `run-adapter`-shaped endpoint at all, so there is nothing for any value of any type to reach. The type is named in advance so the future slice — a `GET / POST` pair, a first real variant, and the review that comes with adding it — has an obvious home when a served repository actually needs automated test execution; it does not itself enforce anything yet, and describing it as already doing so would be exactly the "declaration that names a guarantee nothing enforces" this project has already found and fixed in a census table once this same day (the funnel-row gap PR #695's review caught) — the same defect shape, on a type instead of on a table. Building the config-file alternative now, before anything needs a second adapter, is exactly the complexity the "Future Me Check" this project holds itself to would reject — but so is naming a compile-time guarantee this code does not provide.

## Alternatives considered

---

- **Maintain the app's own bisect session model, backed by its own durable store.** Rejected: two sources of truth for the same session is precisely the failure mode §1 exists to

avoid, and git already durably tracks everything except free-text notes.

- **Parse `BISECT_LOG`'s `#`-prefixed comment lines instead of its command lines.** Rejected: the comments are git's own human-readable annotation of the command that follows, not a second data source — parsing both would invite them to disagree; the command lines are the format `git bisect replay` itself trusts, so this app trusts the same thing.
- **`BisectMark` carrying `{ commit: Commit0id }` for an explicit compare-and-swap.** Rejected for the reason `SequenceContinue` already gives: the repository knows which commit is under test; asking the client invites a stale client to mark the wrong one. If a future need for optimistic-concurrency detection arises, `enforce_fresh`-style staleness checking (ADR 0018) already has a home for it without adding a field here.
- **Reuse `RecoveryStrategy::NotNeeded` for `BisectStart / BisectMark`.** Rejected in §4 above — HEAD does move, and the tag would misstate that.
- **A per-repo, admin-edited adapter config file.** Considered seriously (§7) and deferred, not rejected outright — it is the right design *if* more than one served repository ever needs its own distinct adapter. #87 does not have that need yet, so building the file format, its parser, and its reload story now would be speculative.
- **Hardcode one adapter (e.g. `cargo test --workspace`) as a sensible default.** Rejected: this app serves arbitrary repositories, and a Rust-specific default would silently misbehave (or simply fail) against any other kind of project the operator points it at.

## Consequences

---

- A bisect session is exactly as durable as git's own bisect state already is — restart-proof for free, with no new failure mode for "the app's copy disagreed with git's."



- The activity feed gains one new, precise kind rather than an `Other` fallback or a `Checkout` misclassification.
- The security boundary for automated execution, right now, is that no `run-adapter`-shaped endpoint exists at all — a scope guarantee, not a type-system one. `BisectAdapterId` is an unwired, zero-variant placeholder nothing in this codebase constructs, matches, or routes through; it names where a future reviewed set would live, and claims nothing about what is enforced today.
- The cost paid for the compiled-in-table design, once a future slice wires it up, is that adding the first real adapter needs a code change and a PR, not a config edit. Given #87 ships neither the adapter nor the endpoint, that cost is not yet incurred by anyone.
- `git bisect reset`'s exit-code quirk (the step that finds the culprit exits 1) means the executor must be tested against that exact case, not only the "still narrowing" case — the mutation proof below covers both.

## Mutation proof

---

Both `discover_bisect_state`'s "finished" derivation (§2) and the `RecoveryStrategy::BisectReset` `recovery/reset` roundtrip are mutation-proved two disjoint ways each via `failure-atlas`'s `mutation_check` — see the PR for `run_key`, mutation ids and caught/survived counts; recorded here once the implementation lands rather than guessed at in advance.

The route/handler wiring for the three `/api/bisect/*` endpoints (added after this ADR's design section was written) is mutation-proved two disjoint ways as well, but **by hand, not via `failure-atlas`**: `mutation_check`'s throwaway clone could not build `git-vista-server`'s `gv-sandbox` shim binary, a pre-existing gap unrelated to this feature (hit independently by two lanes the same night). Applied and reverted manually in the working tree instead:

1. **Wrong route → handler mapping** ( `main.rs` routed `/api/bisect/mark` to `bisect_reset` ) — caught by the existing `every_git_write_route_reaches_the_planner` census.
2. **Handler ignoring its request body**, hardcoding a verdict — the existing host-level pipeline tests ( `bisect*_executes_through_the_pipeline` ) call the planner directly and do **not** reach this bug, since they bypass the HTTP handler entirely. Caught by the new `ci/browser/tests/bisect.spec.mjs` , which asserts against `git bisect log` 's own output rather than "no error was shown" — a handler constructing the wrong `GitOperation` still returns 200.

Both legs re-verified green on the real (reverted) code afterward.